Agent Power Levels (APL)

by Michael Negele

Power Level	Level 1 (Zero Setup)	Level 2 (Light Setup)	Level 3 (Full Developer Setup)	Level 4 (System Setup)
	UI-Only Mode Power: ★☆☆☆	**IDE Power Mode** Power: ★★☆☆	**IDE + CLI Mode** Power: ★★★☆	**Agent Ecosystem Mode** Power: ★★★★
What it is	"Chatting in a browser. Nothing installed."	"You install an IDE with built-in AI."	"AI works inside your editor and your terminal."	"Multi-agents + tools, unleashed in Autopilot mode."
Unlocks	• Ideas • Draft code • Concepts • Simple prototypes	• File editing • Repo awareness • Real code changes • Basic refactoring	• Runs commands • Fixes errors • Installs packages • Starts servers • Debugs issues • Handles real dev workflows	• Tool calling • Multiple agents working together • Workflow orchestration • Automated builds/tests/deployments • AI acting like a system, not a chat window
Limitations	• No real project access • No execution • No tools • Manual copy/paste	• No terminal • No system commands • Depends on local skills	• More setup required • Requires trust + supervision	• Requires setup knowledge • Most powerful but most responsibility
Examples	Lovable, ChatGPT UI, Gemini Chat, Claude.ai, etc.	Cursor, Windsurf, Antigravity, VS Copilot, Cline, etc.	Claude Code, Gemini CLI, Cursor Agent, Codex CLI, DeepSeek via Cline, OpenRouter, Ollama, etc.	LangGraph, CrewAI, AutoGen, AWS Bedrock, Azure Open AI, Vertex AI, etc.

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